

Cut off the king with a rook

Endgame Technique

THE IDEA

A rook can deny an entire rank or file to the enemy king. This can keep the king away from a passed pawn or reduce the defending side's coordination. Maintain the cutoff only while the rook itself remains safe and useful.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A rook controlling a file between the enemy king and your passer can force the king to take a longer route. If you abandon that file for a minor pawn gain, the king may reach the blockade in time.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What should you calculate before moving a cutting-off rook?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Whether the enemy king can cross the barrier on the next move and whether that entry changes the pawn race or fortress. Sometimes maintaining restriction is worth more than a pawn.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

A rook's barrier can be more valuable than its immediate capture.